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It's a bumper crop of promises for the farmer, as all parties roll out a bonanza



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BLESSINGS ON OFFER
Shivraj Chouhan campaigning in Sehore, Oct. 26

with a hike in incentives for landless farmers from Rs 7,000 to Rs 10,000 and a promise to set up food processing units in every district. The BJP manifesto, on November 3, dangled the promise of a Rs 3,100 MSP. Two days later, the Congress manifesto bettered that by another hundred rupees.

The farm vote is a useful shift away from the caste factor for Baghel. Chhattisgarh's Congress CM is a Kurmi, and his rival BJP was trying to woo back the Sahu bloc—both are OBC castes, and primarily agrarian. The Sahus, traditionally BJP voters, had moved away in 2018 in the hope that the Congress would make one of their own, Tamradhwaj Sahu, the CM or at least deputy CM. That did not happen. The estrangement deepened this April, when a Sahu youth was killed in a communal incident in Biranpur. In the air of polarisation following that, the BJP has found it opportune to project Bilaspur MP Arun Sao—contesting from Lormi constituency in Mungeli district—as a significant face. Baghel knows he would be better off speaking to farmers as a collective group than get too entangled in inter-caste antagonisms.

He's well placed to do that. Chhattisgarh is the third largest contributor to government paddy procurement after Punjab and Haryana, but the state's farmers get the best pay cheques. The Baghel government topped off the original central MSP of Rs 2,060 with an additional Rs 600. In the last marketing year, 10.75 million tonnes of paddy were purchased from 2.34 million farmers in the state: that translates to some Rs 28,500 crore in payments. The tradition of the bonus on MSP was started by the Raman Singh-led BJP regime, which earned him the tag of "Chawal Baba". Farmers got an additional Rs 300 then. Baghel doubled that, and is hoping to reap his second harvest.

Not if the BJP can help it, of course. Outside of MP, which it rules, it only has central policy to fall back on in these states. And here, it's torn between two approaches. One is attuned to electoral exigencies. So, as it waded into campaigning and sensed the direction of the wind, the Centre thought it fit to announce an enhanced MSP for all rabi crops on October 18, almost a month before sowing was to start. That covered wheat, lentil, mustard and other key crops—wheat, the major rabi crop, will fetch an additional Rs 110 per quintal in marketing season '23-24. Even rabi paddy got a leg-up to Rs 2,203. Then, on October 24, the Union cabinet fixed the nutrient-based subsidy rates for rabi season '23-24 on phosphatic and potassic fertilisers, entailing an additional outgo of Rs 22,300 crore. It also talks of the Rs 6,000 under PM-KISAN on all its platforms.

The Fiscal Dilemma

But then, it's also yoked to fiscal exigencies. In the past six years, as farm debt waiver politics saw a revival, the Centre took a prohibitive stance, insisting states would have to bear the burden themselves. In 2017, when the BJP's Yogi Adityanath came to power on similar commitments in Uttar Pradesh, the Centre refused to open its purse-strings even for him. Nor can it let go of electoral considerations. Hence the competitive bidding on MSP in Chhattisgarh, besides the promise Rs 10,000 to landless labourers—indeed, a full bushel of sops matching that of the Congress. At the same time, the party leans towards the language of efficiencies. For instance, by promising to create a marketing network for those who take up natural farming and millets.

THE BJP OFTEN GETS TORN BETWEEN TWO IMPERATIVES: FISCAL PRUDENCE AT THE CENTRE, ELECTORAL POPULISM IN STATES

In MP, too, BJP leaders speak of a revival of the farm sector, with CM Shivraj Singh Chouhan anchoring massive irrigation access, taking the number of power connections for irrigation pumps from 1.3 million in 2010-11 to over 3.2 million as FY24 dawned. State data shows that, until 2009-10, canals in the state irrigated 800,000 hectares during the rabi season. That trebled to 2.4 million hectares by FY15 and crossed 3.3 million hectares in FY23. The average farm in MP grows 1.8 crops—only marginally below the best in the country, Punjab and Haryana's 1.9, whereas it is only 1.5 for Rajasthan.

There's a flip side to this focus on macros, though. Despite the highest share among all states (44.2 per cent) in their gross value added column, and despite clocking double-digit agricultural growth in the past decade, the